

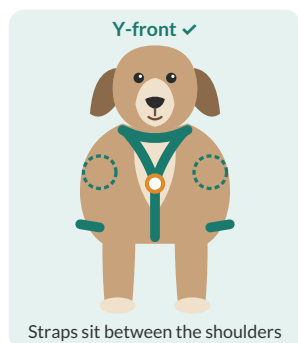


Setting Your Dog Up for Walking Success

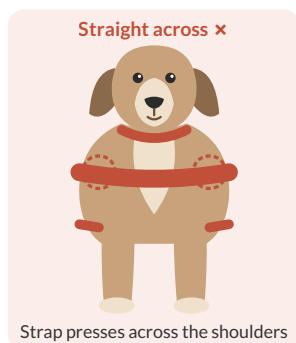
The right kit makes a calm, loose-lead walk so much easier for you both

Walks should be the best part of your dog's day, but for a nervous or excitable dog they can be a lot. Good equipment won't train your dog for you, but the **wrong equipment can make walks harder**, more uncomfortable and more stressful.

The harness: leave the shoulders free



Straps sit between the shoulders



Strap presses across the shoulders

A dog's shoulders need to move freely with every stride. Harnesses with a **strap straight across the chest** can restrict that movement and, over time, change how your dog walks.

Choose a **Y-front harness**, where the straps form a "Y" and sit on the breastbone, between the shoulders. Ideally pick one with **two rings**: one on the chest and one on the back.

Checking the fit

- You can slide **two fingers** under every strap.
- The front of the "Y" sits on the **breastbone**, not on the throat.
- The strap behind the front legs sits a hand's width back, so it **doesn't rub the armpits**.
- It doesn't twist or slide when your dog moves. Re-check as puppies grow.

The lead: clear and simple

Use a **2 m double-ended training lead**, clipped to both the chest and back rings. Two points of contact give you gentle, balanced steering without pulling on any one spot.

For sniffing and exploring in safe, open spaces, a **long line** (5 to 10 m) clipped to the **back ring** gives your dog freedom while keeping them safe.

Kit at a glance

	What we recommend	What to avoid, and why
Harness	Well-fitted Y-front with chest and back rings	Straight-across chest straps, which restrict the shoulders; harnesses that tighten when the dog pulls
Lead	2 m double-ended training lead; long line for sniffing time	Bungee leads : there is always some tension, so your dog never feels a truly loose lead. Retractable leads : constant pull, and hard to control quickly
Neck	A flat collar for your dog's ID tag only, not for attaching the lead	Slip, choke or prong collars and anything that tightens or causes discomfort; these can increase fear and reactivity



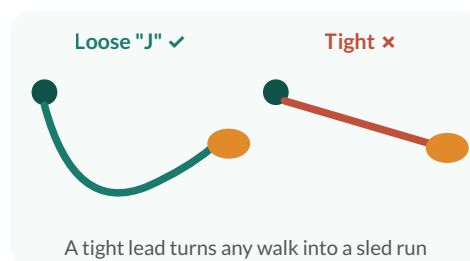
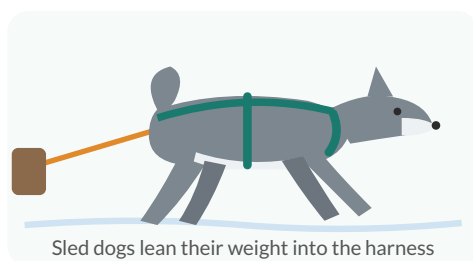
Planning a Calmer Walk

Before you go, while you're out, and when you get home

Why dogs pull

Dogs naturally **lean into pressure**. When something pulls them backwards, their instinct is to push forwards against it, often called the **opposition reflex**. So the harder we pull back on the lead, the harder most dogs pull forward. It isn't stubbornness; it's how dogs are built.

People have relied on this for thousands of years. **Sled dogs** such as huskies and malamutes, and the draught dogs that once pulled carts, wear harnesses that put the pressure across the chest so they can throw their whole weight into it. The more resistance behind them, the harder they pull. A **tight lead on a back clip** recreates that same set-up, which is why we keep the lead loose, use the chest ring to gently turn rather than resist, and **stop and wait** instead of pulling back.



Before you go

- **Check the stress bucket.** After a busy or stressful day, choose a quieter walk, or a Free Work session at home instead.
- **Calm exits.** Wait until your dog is settled before opening the door.
- **Pick your route and time.** Quiet places at quiet times help a nervous dog cope.
- **Bring what your dog loves.** Tasty treats suit many dogs; others would rather have a favourite toy.

While you're out

- **Let your dog sniff.** It's how dogs read the world, and it's naturally calming.
- **Make space early.** Curve around, cross the road or turn away before your dog becomes worried.
- **Reward the good moments** (a loose lead, a check-in) with a treat, toy, sniff or praise.
- **Watch the signals.** Lip licks, head turns and slowing down mean your dog needs more space.
- **Treat refused?** A dog who won't take food or a toy they usually love is often **too stressed**. Add distance and ease off.

When you get home, give your dog time to rest; recovery is how the stress bucket drains. And **it's OK to skip a walk** if your dog is unsettled, unwell or the bucket is full. Sniffing games or Free Work can meet their needs just as well.

⚠ Never use the lead to correct

Jerking or holding the lead tight causes discomfort and fear, and a worried dog can link other dogs or people with that feeling. If your dog pulls, **stop, wait for slack, then carry on**, and talk to Flo about a plan.